i dreamed i was a baseball card

By Richard Stockton Rand

SPEAKER: **(Pg 31-43)** I dreamed I was a baseball card. A baseball card. You pull out your stack. Start completely still. See him in your hand. Looking up at you. Flip. Heads. Flip. Heads. Heroes of the game. Flip. It's in the fingers. Flip. Always the same. Forever. Mounds of baseball cards looking up at you. Take them home. Put 'em in a shoebox. Hide 'em under the bed - where I listened to them Yankees on my radio, cause my father didn't trust baseball. I'd listen under the bed to night games at the Stadium. It was like being down in the Yankee dugout with the sound of a million people echoing in your ears. My sister could hear the crowd cheering clear out of my ear-plug, "The Mick just hit one out," I'd say. That's Mick -- The Mick. Mickey Mantle.

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INTRODUCTION

Who was your hero when you were 9 years old? When you were too little to be amazing, but your imagination could get you there anyway? Remember imagination . . . that's what kids used before the internet! In your imagination, you could BE Mickey Mantle, or a sports announcer, or Bilbo Baggins from The Hobbit or even. . . invisible. Imagination was the ultimate escape. In this selection, we experience the world through the eyes of a young boy who is both idealistic and desperately trying to escape a situation he doesn't quite understand. Can he save himself and his sister and hit one out of the park like Mickey Mantle, or is being invisible the only answer?

I Dreamed I was a Baseball Card by Richard Stockton Rand

SPEAKER: The hush of the crowd, the voice of the Ole Redhead: "Full count on Mantle." If you think hard enough you can make it happen. "He swings. It's a fly to deep centerfield. It's, IT'S, IT'S OUTTAhere! Mantle wins the game in the bottom of the ninth inning." It works, too. That was me as Ole Red, The Redhead, Red Barber. I was honing my play by play skills – "Hard grounder to MacDouglas, over to Rizzuto who leaps over the sliding Stanky, back to first, double play!" -- for my future career as a Yankee broadcaster. This is after I got in the Hall of Fame for stealing the most

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bases, ‘cause I was fast, you bet, ‘specially when I was being chased.

And that’s how I found this hiding place. My dad was looking for me, and I’d slid under my sister’s bed. In winter, when I couldn’t get out, I needed a secret hiding space. That’s how I found under the bed. He was on his way to looking under there. He did look under there. But he didn’t see me. Know why?

Because I’m invisible. See, I seen this rip in the box spring and I could squeeze through perfect, like a secret passage. What a place! There were globs of cotton with springs sticking through ‘em and these boards I could lie down on perfect. And nobody found me. Never. Not ever. They looked, too. But I was invisible. Inside the boxspring I could sleep safe with my radio, and I’d dream I was a baseball card living inside the Hall of Fame. That’s how I saved myself.

Being invisible paid off in Little League too. I was #7, Mickey Mantle. Your number’s who you are. It was all in the number. Feel the Mick. Number 7 on my back. All through me, pinstripes, through my heart, and hurt.

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The Mick’s always hurt. It’s in the knees. Can’t get out. I was The Mick. And nobody could pitch to me. To be a good pitcher you have to have good stuff and good control. And you got to be fast. When we were in trouble, I step to the mound. I was the short man. The Stopper. Got the ball in my hand. Turning. I look in to home. I knew what I had to do. Fastball. STEERIIIKE! Then I knew being little meant something.

I practiced pitching in my room ‘til my Mom’d say goodnight. Then, I’d sneak into my sister’s room, squeeze into the boxspring and turn invisible. My sister and I talked to each other through the mattress while they were fighting downstairs. I’d tell her how the game’s going like the Ole Redhead: “It’s back, back, back, back Ohhhhh-HO, Doctor! Mantle’s flagged it down by the monuments!” Then after the game, she’d read to me. And he’d leave us alone mostly, if we didn’t make no noise, ‘til one night.

. . . he comes in. Just stands there. Could feel him. Thought for sure he’d found me. But he’s watching her.

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She pretends she's asleep. It was a long time he stayed there. . . breathing. Could hear him . . . breathing. Feel his shadow. Then he sits . . . on the edge . . . of her bed, the mattress sagging damn near on top of me.

Then, every night he comes up, sits down: same time, Mom's watching Johnny Carson, and he stares at her pretending she's asleep. Then it starts. He's moving the covers, whispering to her. She's making sounds like trying to not make sounds. I hear laughing on TV downstairs, springs moving next to me. And the noises. I can't . . . move. The mattress's pressing down on me and they're right there. So I turn invisible. Turn up the sound 'til there's only Yankee Stadium and the crowd screaming in my ear. Then it's over. The mattress stops. Hear his shoes on the floor and he's down the stairs humming like nothing happened. Mom never says nothing. Just sits watching Johnny Carson. Nobody says nothing. Every night it happens. 'Til once, he's coming up, she says, "What should I do?" "Hide," I tell her. "Where?" she says. "Invisible." "How?" "Little. Little. Like a dot!," I tell her. But she couldn't do it.

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Footsteps on the stairs, humming like nothing's going to happen. Then he's there. Big heavy shoes. Staring. Sits. On the edge of her bed. Every night. Then it starts. I don't want to be there, but I couldn't leave her.

Then she thought of a way. It was getting cold, so she'd stay up all night putting her head out the window. And it worked. She got real sick. And she kept doing it 'til the doctor quarantined her. Now nobody could touch her.

Pretty good thing. We rigged up two cans and a string through the bedroom windows and we planned our escape the whole time. I'd bring her meals up with secret notes under the grapefruit, and she'd roll her pills under the door for me to get rid of. Meals went in and plates came out for months she stayed sick. She was playing her cards right. Five months without going to school. She learned how to be invisible without even knowing it and now nobody could touch her. She stayed in there studying and got hundreds on all her exams!

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But she started feeling better in the spring, and we knew we had to make a getaway plan. We got the idea from this book, The Hobbit, she read for English about these two guys that went off to find another world after where they lived stopped being safe. And boy, that sounded right for us. See, this Bilbo Baggins was the lead guy, and he lived in a place underground, like a . . . dugout. And he was a little guy, like a leprechaun, but baggy. And she reads to me all night about his adventures and we plan our escape.

We decide to write a letter to Mickey and we tell him everything. Then instead of going to school, I take her on the train up to Yankee Stadium. We sit in the bleachers and wait for The Mick to come out and take flies. We got the letter all ready for me to run out on the field. But he don't come out. My sister and me went back home, but she got real sick from not having been outside all winter. They put her in the hospital the next day with a high fever. Seventh floor. Mickey's

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number. She got so bad they had to put her in intensive care. They said she was gonna die.

Summer went into fall. The Yankees came in last place for the first time ever. One day, [Dad] took me to visit her cause she was having trouble remembering things. When I walked in she smiled right off, but no matter what she couldn't recognize him. Over the next few months she had five operations. The doctors couldn't understand why she kept rejecting her medication. It's cause she wasn't taking it! She went into a coma for days and she would call out in the night, "Ohhhhhh-Ho Doctor! Going Back, Back, Back, Going, Going . . . " And I prayed to the leprechauns. Then one day she woke up. She told me 'bout a dream. She was in great danger. The leprechauns came and took her on a train to heaven. She steps out into a bunch of clouds and this baseball's heading right at her, and it's a Mickey homerun. She reaches out to grab it and it's me, my head, inside the baseball, saying "Don't give up." She was on and off for months, but she kept coming back.

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My mother took me to visit her in the spring. It was a real warm day and the nurse said I could take her outside, so I rode her round the bases at the park across the street. I did the play by play and had her steal home with the bases loaded. Said it was the happiest day of her life. When we got back, the doctor asked her if she wanted to go home and she told him what happened . . . on the bed. He must have told my mother cause we went home and packed up her stuff quick while Dad's at work. Then she flew away . . . with the leprechauns.

It was just me then. Waiting for him. To find out. I hear the garage. Then he comes up, asks how she is. It's quiet. Something's going to happen. I'm waiting . . . . She must be telling him. He starts moving . . . fast! Doors slamming! Then. Plates. Hitting the walls. I feel 'em shake. 'Til there's no more plates. Then he's up the stairs, in her room. Pulling drawers out, sees her clothes gone, slams her door, over and over. Doors slamming, over and over. Then he's down, down to get her. "Don't touch me!" [Mom] says. "I know what

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happened . . . up there. That stops him. Then nothing. Nothing. He just sits in the kitchen eating oatmeal and reading the paper.

But I can feel him down there getting mad, see him through the floor like a bomb moving. Then the doors start . . . . banging. Over and over. All night. But I'm ready for him, holding the bat, case he comes in. Practice my swing in the dark. SWING. See his face moving. SWING. The words coming out of his moth. SWING. The sound of the swoosh. SWING. And his head flies out of the ballpark . . .

I go to school to get somewhere safe. Stay late at the library, then ride the trains back and forth doing my homework or listening to the Yankess. "He's going back, back, back . . ." Back home when he's asleep and leave before he gets up. But one morning, he's up the stairs in my room with a bat, standing over me screaming, and I don't know what I did, but it's bad. And I can't move, can't get the words out. And I'm waiting for it, waiting for him to finally hit me. Then I see the Mickey Mantle bat in his hands and I just want

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him to swing, just want him to hit me out like Mickey would at Yankee Stadium, so I could feel my head fly out of the ballpark, and not have to think anymore when he's finally going to kill me. I say, "Hit me." But he don't understand. "Hit me!," I said. And he stops cause the voice is coming out of me loud, screaming, like his voice, and he's scared. And it's like I was him now, like he was me, little, little like me. And he can't touch me. Nobody can touch me. Never. Not ever. Cause I ain't invisible.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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